



Self-destructing messages

WhatsApp is working on self-destructing messages and a dark mode feature. <https://dgit.in/dec19-21>



No more pop-up cameras?

Popular phone brands Redmi, Realme to Vivo are making the shift to punch hole display smartphones. <https://dgit.in/dec19-22>

DARK PATTERNS

Manipulative design in UX is eerily omnipresent. Here's everything you need to know about this unethical practice.

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X or user experience designers use their expertise in cognitive psychology and usability to conjure up the

best experience on websites for internet users. Or at least, they're supposed to. More often than not, UX designers go down the unscrupulous path of using their knowledge of psychological biases in creating user experiences that are meant to mislead, misdirect or misinform you as a content consumer. Commonly known as 'dark patterns', this type of UX design caters specifically to a business' interests and goals, be it more sales, data or subscribers.

What's the problem, you ask? Aren't businesses supposed to target profitability and growth? Businesses must indeed strive to rack up profits, but there are ways of doing it without snatching away a user's agency and must employ methods that benefit the users and the businesses. It is a conundrum that has had corporates, businesses and users grappling at the roots of their hair for ages and all for good reason. Let's delve further into 'dark patterns'.

WHAT ARE DARK PATTERNS

Dark Patterns are certain interfaces designed meticulously to purposely mislead users to go down a path they didn't mean to take. They sideline basic

ethics and the user's needs to reach a company's business objectives. While 'dark patterns' are nothing novel and have been utilised in UX design for ages now, the term itself is relatively new.

In 2010, Harry Brignull, a London-based UX designer created a website – darkpatterns.org – that highlights an array of examples of deliberately deceptive user interfaces. If you think you've never encountered such misdemeanours on a website interface, think again. Most of us have had first-hand experiences of having problems unsubscribing from a service or newsletter or getting rid of pesky pop-ups on the screen.

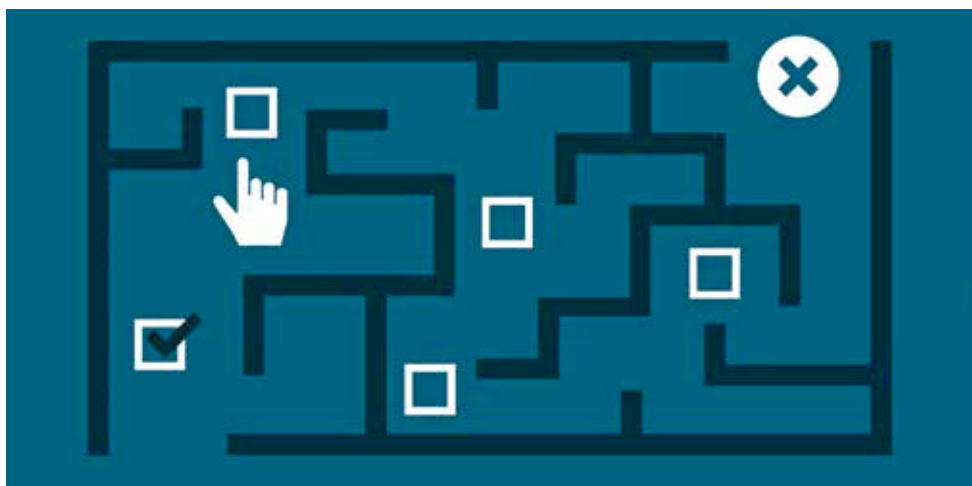
The technique exploits one of the most commonly-seen practices exhibited by content-overloaded consumers today, which is merely skimming through content rather than actually delving into their meaning and implications. We're even more prone to skimming through stuff that looks dull, unappealing or boring on the surface.

In order to execute 'dark patterns' designs well, manipulative timing

is integral. A user is more prone not to ignore said patterns, which will cause them to sign up for a service, notifications or monthly payment, when they are already in the midst of a task.

For example, if you've found an article online that you find very interesting, you'll click on the link. You may be able to read the first line or paragraph after which a pop-up or 'Continue' button will appear which makes you sign up for the remainder of the article. Content consumers will just end up signing up despite not wanting to, just because they want to know what comes after so desperately. UX designers are also meticulous enough to ensure that the 'juicy bit' is right after the sign-up process.

What users don't realise is that by giving away your email address, through the normal sign up process or through social media, you have invited a horde of unwanted emails in your inbox. Unsubscribing to these emails? Well, the dark patterns don't just stop at the website, do they? The unsubscribe button is usually in the place



Meet Harry Brignull. A UX designer himself who coined the term 'dark patterns' in 2010